

RURAL ROAD (R2) OR RURAL LANE (R3)?

A classification question for the Planning Board – Article 3, Thoroughfares

Revised August 24, 2026. An earlier version of this memo asked the Board to choose a test for applying R3 more broadly. Since then the information needed to apply the better test became available and the classification has been carried out. The question before the Board has changed accordingly, and is now narrower.

WHAT HAS CHANGED SINCE THIS MEMO WAS FIRST WRITTEN

The earlier memo set out four options. Option 3 was to classify by **how many dwellings a way actually serves** – the test that matches the Code’s own language, which describes R3 in terms of traffic volume rather than length. That memo recommended against it for one reason only: “the Town does not currently hold dwellings-served counts for each way; they would have to be gathered.”

They have since been gathered. The Town’s E-911 address data records one point for every addressed structure in Newcastle – 1,227 of them. Counting the residential addresses along each segment gives a direct reading of how many homes it serves.

Two things about this deserve to be stated plainly:

- **The counts sorted the work; they did not decide it.** Every classification below was reviewed and set by hand. The counts said where to look first.
- **About a quarter of the Town’s address points carry no record of what kind of structure they are.** Where a segment shows no residential address but does show a structure of unrecorded type, that means *not yet reviewed*, not *nothing there*. Those were judged individually.

The length test this memo previously recommended was not used. It is not needed now, and it was always a rough stand-in: a 900 ft lane serving three houses carries no more traffic than a 400 ft lane serving three houses.

WHERE THE CLASSIFICATION NOW STANDS

	Before	Now
R3 Rural Lane	4 segments	66
R2 Rural Road	126 segments	70
Recorded as a driveway today	4	61

Measured against the dwellings-served test, the R3 group is coherent: of the 66 segments now classified R3, **46 serve one or two homes, 19 serve none on record, and one serves three or four. None serves five or more.**

WHY THIS REDUCES OBLIGATIONS RATHER THAN INCREASING THEM

R3 is the *lighter* standard. This is not a technicality; it decides how much work a property owner must do if a lane is ever improved.

	R2 Rural Road	R3 Rural Lane
Right-of-way (build to)	40 ft	33 ft
Traveled way (build to)	18 ft, two 9 ft lanes	12 ft, one shared lane
Design speed	25 mph	15 mph
Curb return radius	25 ft	15 ft
Surface	Paved or gravel	Gravel
Maximum grade	12%	12%
Sight distance	Per Table 3.2	Per Table 3.2

The safety standards – sight distance, maximum grade, drainage – are identical. What differs is width and surface.

Under Section 7.F, a driveway that grows to serve more than two dwellings must be improved to the Type assigned to it. At R2 that means an 18 ft traveled way in a 40 ft right-of-way; at R3 it means a 12 ft shared gravel surface in a 33 ft right-of-way. **Moving these lanes to R3 substantially reduces what a future owner would have to build.** Nothing about the reclassification requires any work on any existing way.

WHAT THE BOARD IS NOW ASKED TO DO

First: ratify the classification as it stands – 66 segments at R3, and 61 segments recorded as functioning today as driveways.

Second: decide nineteen remaining segments. Nineteen privately owned segments still classified R2 serve two homes or fewer on the current record. Under the test as applied to everything else, they would be R3. They were left as they are pending the Board's view.

They fall into three groups:

- **Eight serve two homes** – Bradley Shore Road, Cottage Road, Deer Meadow Road, Dickenson Road, Eagle Point Road, Estey Road, Happy Valley Road, and Jackies Way. Two homes is the driveway threshold itself, so these sit exactly on the line.
- **Four serve one home** – Barrol Point Road, Bay View Road, Osprey Point Road, and Sheepscott River Way.
- **Seven show no residential address on record**, though several show a structure of unrecorded type. These are the least certain of the group and may simply need a look on the ground.

Third: resolve one inconsistency this memo raised before, which is still open. Eden Lane and Camp Road are both privately owned, both show no residential address, and both are short dead-end ways. **Camp Road is classified R3; Eden Lane is still R2.** Nothing in the record distinguishes them. Whatever the Board decides for the nineteen segments above should settle Eden Lane too.

TWO ITEMS CARRIED FORWARD

- **Kavanagh Road and Woods Island Road still have no Ownership Category recorded.** Neither matched a State or E-911 jurisdiction record. This needs checking against the Town's own road records.
- **The 11-foot Station Road fragment has been removed** from the Inventory as a mapping artifact. That item is closed.

A NOTE ON HOW THIS CARRIES FORWARD

Every classification recorded here is durable. When the Town's district mapping is finalized and the underlying data is refreshed, these decisions carry forward automatically – no decision has to be made twice, and nothing the Board settles today will need revisiting because of a data update.